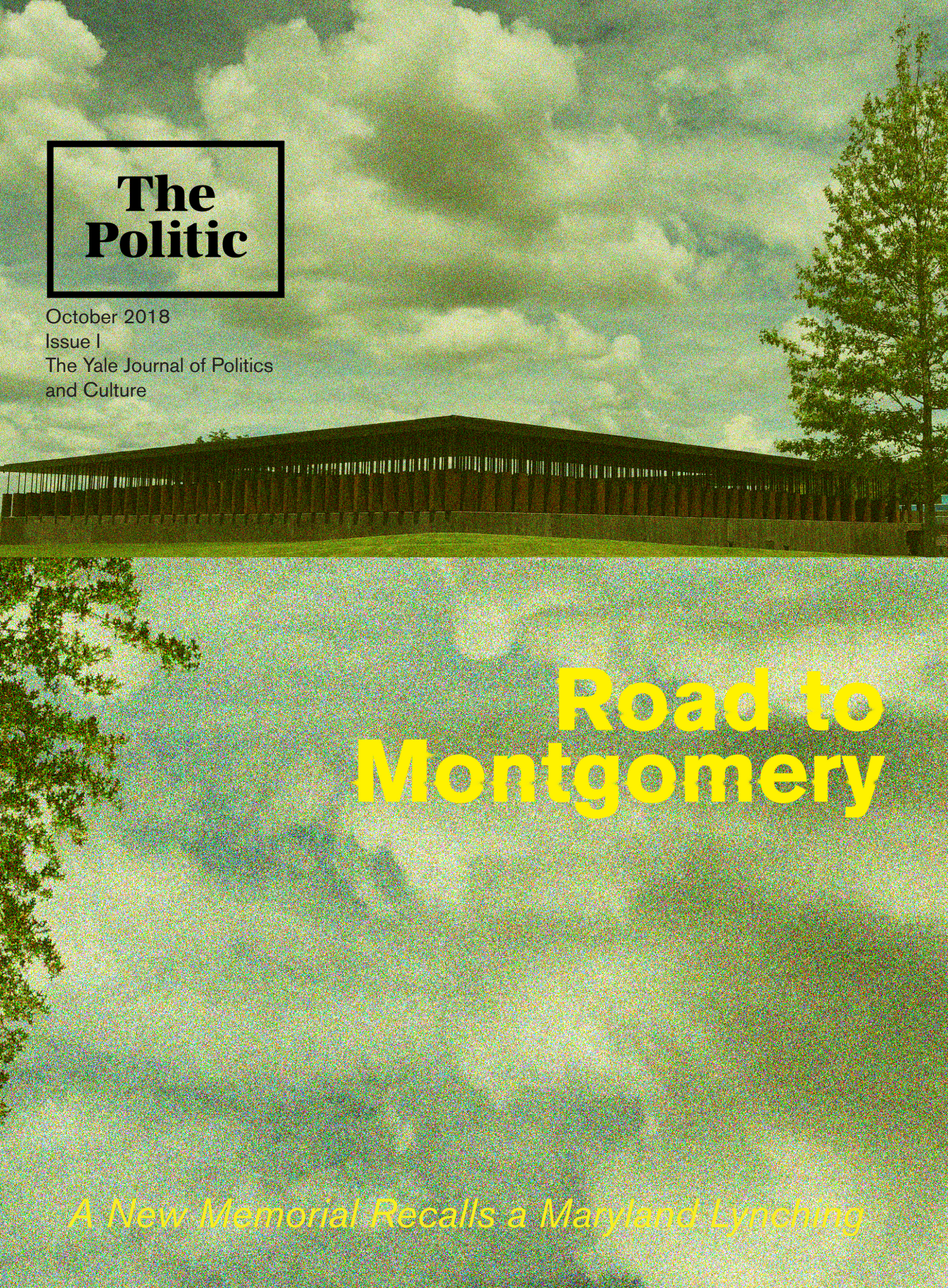

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Road to Montgomery

A New Memorial Recalls a Maryland Lynching

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The Politic

SEBASTIAN QUAADE 2 **WHEN POP GOES POLITICAL**
Ugandan Singer Bobi Wine Challenges an Entrenched Regime

VANESSA ZHANG 7 **"HEROIN PILLS, BLOOD MONEY"**
Yale Stays Silent on Ties to a Big Pharma Family

JAKE LEFFEW 11 **UNFREEDOM OF THE PRESS**
A War on Journalists in Mexico

PETER ROTHPLETZ *senior staff writer* 15 **"OMBUDSMAN OF THE ROOM"**
An Interview with Jake Tapper

T.C. MARTIN *senior staff writer* 18 **COVER**
ROAD TO MONTGOMERY
A New Memorial Recalls a Maryland Lynching

ANASTASIA HUFHAM 24 **EDUCATED WHILE INCARCERATED**
A New Initiative Brings Yale to a Connecticut Prison

ALAN MAY 26 **BUDGET PROBLEMS IN BRIDGEPORT**
In Connecticut's Largest City, the Money Has Dried Up

SHANNON SOMMERS 31 **SKIN IN THE GAME**
Spike Lee's *BlacKkKlansman* Shows the Darkness and Durability of American Racism

When Pop Goes Political

Ugandan Singer Bobi Wine Challenges an Entrenched Regime

BY **SEBASTIAN QUAADE**

PHOTO COURTESY OF **BOBI WINE/FACEBOOK**

AFTER A LONG DAY of campaigning and a celebratory evening tea, Ugandan musician Bobi Wine was climbing the stairs to his hotel room in the Pacific Hotel of Arua, a city in northern Uganda, when he heard one of his drivers calling him back to the parking lot. When he returned to his car, Bobi Wine found his other driver, Yasin Kawuma, dead. He believes Kawuma was shot by soldiers from the Ugandan army.

"Those bullets were meant for me," Bobi Wine told me.

Uganda's armed forces do not typically target musicians. Robert Kyagulanyi Ssentamu—better known by his stage name, Bobi Wine—is one of East Africa's most beloved pop singers, and since 2017, he also has been an elected member of parliament. Nicknamed "the ghetto president," Bobi Wine has done more than most to provoke the wrath of his country's authoritarian regime, using his star power to help stir anti-government sentiment. The day his driver was killed, August 13, 2018, was voting day in Arua, where Bobi Wine had been campaigning for his friend Kassiano Wadri in a parliamentary by-election.

Wadri won, defeating Nusura Tiperu of President Yoweri Museveni's National Resistance Movement (NRM). Within 24 hours, Bobi Wine's driver was dead, and Bobi Wine himself was detained on dubious charges of illegal firearm possession.

Bobi Wine alleges that police officers tortured him in jail, jabbing his ankles with pistol butts, pulling his ears with pliers, injecting him with unknown fluids, and hitting his back and genitals with objects he was unable to identify. "I groaned in pain and they ordered me to stop making noise for them," Bobi Wine wrote in a Facebook post. "They forced my head below the car seat so as to stop me from shouting."

After ten days, Bobi Wine was brought before a judge in Gulu, a city in northern Uganda, and the charges against him were dropped. In court, Bobi Wine broke down in tears.

Yet, as he staggered down the courthouse steps, leaning heavily on his crutches and assisted by a crowd of men, he received word—broadcast live on television—that he was being rearrested, now for treason against the state. Police officers promptly whisked him away to another prison.

This time, the Ugandan youth, Bobi Wine's most fervent fan base, had had enough. Protests broke out in many of the country's biggest cities. In response, Uganda's elite army unit, the Special Forces Command (SFC), was deployed in Kampala, and snipers roamed the city, according to news reports.

"All the police stations, they are having more guys, and their armored

cars are out," said "Kato," a Kampala resident and Bobi Wine supporter who spoke on the condition of anonymity because he feared retaliation. In some cases, protesters met tear gas and live ammunition. At least six have been killed, and many more have been injured.

CLASHES BETWEEN CIVILIANS and state security forces are not common in Uganda, but they have become a feature of the dogged political battles fought in Uganda over the last 30 years. Since seizing power in 1986, Yoweri Museveni has held a firm grip on authority. For almost two decades, opposition parties were effectively banned, and a series of constitutional amendments has allowed Museveni to remain in office well beyond his original term limits. The latest is the removal of the presidential age limit: Museveni, 74, is now eligible to run in the 2021 presidential elections. He is currently in the thirty-second year of his presidency.

Political opposition to Museveni has existed in Uganda for most of his rule, and Bobi Wine is not the first government critic to reportedly face torture. But Bobi Wine's enormous popularity among Uganda's youth poses a new and powerful threat to the regime. Uganda's population is among the youngest in the world: according to the United Nations Population Fund, almost four in five Ugandans are younger than 30 years old. In recent years, widespread corruption and high youth unemployment rates—estimated to be 80 percent by the International Youth Foundation—have spurred young Ugandans to protest. "[Bobi Wine] stands for the young person," Kato said. "He was never just the regular artist making the music that we enjoy at the bar."

In 2014, Bobi Wine, still only a musician, recorded a song to warn his government that it was sitting on a "Time Bomb" called youth.

"We are sitting on a time bomb / This time bomb wants to explode / When it goes off / Don't say you didn't see it coming," he sang in the Luganda language.

When Bobi Wine decided to run for public office three years later, he had grown tired of waiting for the time bomb to blow. And this August, when protests broke out after his detention, Bobi Wine may have lit the fuse.

"We are sitting on a time bomb
This time bomb wants to explode
When it goes off
Don't say you didn't see it coming"

DESPITE HIS MUSICAL and political stardom, Bobi Wine manages to remain accessible and eager to meet with youth. Case in point: I wrote to Robert Amsterdam, Bobi Wine's lawyer, asking if it would be possible to arrange an interview with him. Bobi Wine has been swarmed by big-time media after his high-profile imprisonment and torture, so I thought my chance of getting an interview was close to zero.

After two hours, a reply popped up. "Done," Amsterdam wrote. Three days later, I was on the phone with Bobi Wine.

"I grew up knowing Museveni as a liberator," Bobi Wine said. "As a teenager, I admired Museveni so much." He grew up in the slums of Kamwookya, one of Kampala's poorest neighborhoods, and he was only four when Museveni deposed the previous dictator in 1986. Like many other Ugandans, as a child he fostered a deep admiration for the man who brought lasting peace to large parts of the country. This admiration lasted until his early adulthood, when Bobi Wine began to find musical success in Uganda.

In 2005, Bobi Wine recorded his first political hit. The song, "Ghetto," criticized the government for prioritizing the comfort of foreign leaders at a 2007 Commonwealth conference over the well-being of its own citizens. "Ghetto" was quickly adopted as a theme for the opposition's election campaign.

"He's been a leader and mentor through his music before becoming a political figure," Kato said. "He helped young people get educated through something they love."

Bobi Wine has stayed close to his roots—insisting on keeping his recording studio in the slum where he grew up—but he eventually felt he had to do more for Ugandans who were less fortunate. "I decided to run for [political] office after realizing that music wasn't enough to make a change," Bobi Wine told me. In April 2017, Bobi Wine announced his candidacy in a by-election for the parliamentary seat of Kyadondo East, a county in Kampala. His vision appealed to the disenfranchised: "Since Parliament has failed to come to the ghetto," Bobi Wine announced during his campaign, "then we shall bring the ghetto to Parliament."

The regime seemed to recognize immediately the political threat that Bobi Wine posed. Museveni personally visited the NRM candidate Sitenda Sebalu's rallies, making promise after promise of improved access

to education and basic services—if Sebalu won. Security forces arrested Bobi Wine just before he was supposed to hold one of his own rallies. On election day, some newspapers reported that there appeared to be more police and soldiers than voters present at the Kyadondo East polling stations. Still, Bobi Wine won 80 percent of the vote, sweeping aside Sebalu and three other rivals.

After his win, Bobi Wine journeyed to various parts of the country to campaign for candidates he supported, all of whom were government critics. All four candidates that Bobi Wine campaigned for won their constituencies' elections, often by wide margins. It may be his strike rate as a kingmaker that has alarmed the government.

Bobi Wine was playing a key role in rapidly replacing establishment politicians with opposition allies—and he knows he could be made to pay with his life.

THE RUTHLESS TREATMENT of Bobi Wine follows a well-established pattern of Museveni's reign. Kizza Besigye, the longtime face of the opposition, said at a rally in 2015 that he had been arrested and jailed 43 times since the 2011 general election.

"What Bobi Wine has gone through, Besigye has gone through many times over," Charles Odoobo Bichachi, former editor-in-chief at Kampala's *Daily Monitor* newspaper, told me. Besigye is now partially blind due to the brutality involved in his forceful arrests.

The state also has a long history of hostility toward protests. In 1993, a few members of Uganda's Democratic Party (DP) formed an offshoot party and organized a public rally to protest a ban on political activity.

Although the group posed little real threat to his authority, Museveni made a statement in parliament before the protest, according to Agence France Presse: "I have told police to stop gatherings using force," Museveni said. "Tell supporters that they will be killed if they attend political rallies."

On the day of the 1993 rally, tanks and helicopters patrolled Kampala, even though the organizers had called off the protests to prevent a tragedy.

"He fights tomorrow's battle today," Bichachi said of Museveni. The regime is not one to wait until a situation spirals out of control, and the heavy-handed crackdown on Bobi Wine and his supporters may be better read as an attempt to nip an escalating situation in the bud rather than as an act of desperation.

Still, Bobi Wine's political ascent arrives at a moment when the government seems to be losing its total grip on power. "[Museveni's] legitimacy rested on the fact that he restored stability and personal security," said Bichachi, recalling that the current president's rise marked the end of once-widespread violence in most parts of the country.

But recent years have seen a security crisis marked by a drastic rise in high-profile murders. The Arua by-election was called after former Member of Parliament Ibrahim Abiriga was shot dead in a still-unresolved case. Most recently, a tied-up dead body was dumped from a speeding car in broad daylight in a densely populated Kampala neighborhood, just hours after Museveni delivered a national address stressing the government's efforts to curb violence in urban areas.

According to Bichachi, these killings do not bear the hallmarks of a "government job." But since 2012, few perpetrators of violent murders have been brought to justice.

"The murders seem like an attempt to show that Museveni can no longer assure security," Bichachi speculated.

In the face of the security crisis, Museveni's actions have only grown more frantic. On September 9, he

Bobi Wine was playing a key role in rapidly replacing establishment politicians with opposition allies—and he knows he could be made to pay with his life.

ordered 24,000 army reserves to be deployed throughout Kampala as Local Defence Units (LDUs).

He expects the plan to cost around 57 billion Ugandan shillings (roughly 15 million dollars) but said it was "no problem," despite Uganda not having fully recovered from an economic downturn.

"We shall see which guns have more effect," Museveni remarked during his address to the nation on September 9. Many of the LDUs will be stationed in areas with strong support for Bobi Wine.

AFTER ALMOST THREE WEEKS in prison, Bobi Wine was released on bail. As soon as he could, he flew to the U.S. to seek medical attention. He told me that he feared doctors in Uganda would be bought or coerced into harming him, and that he had received numerous tests to ensure that he was not injected with poison while in prison.

But Bobi Wine acknowledged that he had other reasons to come to the U.S. "I have been coming here for many years," he said. "I always use it as a chance to speak to [Uganda's] development partners and talk about how they are contributing to the situation in Uganda." He met with American politicians and civil servants, including Representative Bradley Sherman (D-CA), and asked them to pressure the U.S. government to end military aid to Uganda.

The Ugandan SFC that Bobi Wine claims tortured him has close ties to the U.S. An elite military unit responsible for on-the-ground combat in Somalia, the SFC has received American training and equipment worth millions of dollars.

Less than a year after the Ugandan mission in Somalia began, Museveni appointed his son Muhoozi Kainerugaba as the SFC commander. Some of these troops have been assigned directly to Museveni's presidential guard to follow his personal orders. Many Ugandans believe that they were behind both the violence in Arua and the bloody response to the more recent protests.

"We want the American taxpayer to know that the American taxpayer is funding this," said Bobi Wine's international lawyer Robert Amsterdam at a September 6 news conference in Washington. "The military equipment we are supplying to Uganda is being used in a war of terror against Uganda's citizens."

Bobi Wine's decision to seek treatment in the U.S. has been politically risky. Following Western countries' condemnation of Uganda's domestically popular anti-gay bill, the Ugandan government has encouraged anti-Western sentiment and derided opponents as puppets of Western organizations.

"[Going to the U.S.] works for and against him," said Bichachi. "It has worked for him to give him an international platform to articulate his political beliefs. However, it has also portrayed him as a front for the West. That will not help him politically here." Bichachi added, "If he is seen to be pampered by the West, it will undermine his chances at home."

A FEW WEEKS BEFORE his flight back to Uganda, I asked Bobi Wine what he planned to do upon returning. His answer was fearful: "What happens after I return is not in my control."

The possibility that he could be taken back to prison immediately seemed very real. "Yesterday [Bobi Wine and I] were talking about his return and how we can protect him from any attempt by the government," Norbert Mao, leader of the Democratic Party and Bobi Wine's acquaintance, told me a few days before Bobi Wine left the U.S.

As he feared, Bobi Wine says he was confronted by Ugandan security personnel as soon as his plane touched down in Entebbe on Thursday, September 20. According to his account, police charged into the plane, grabbed him, and shepherded him into one of 14 vehicles that would take him to a then-undisclosed location. Along the Entebbe-Kampala road, soldiers invaded trading centers, beating up shopkeepers and customers to clear the area for the vehicles to pass. For hours, reports circulated that Bobi Wine had been taken back to prison. But later in the day, Kampala's police spokesperson denied the reports, stating that Bobi Wine had simply been "peacefully escorted by the police to his residence."

The big question for Bobi Wine is whether he will challenge Museveni for the presidency in 2021. In interviews with Al Jazeera and the BBC, Bobi Wine has avoided answering questions about his ambitions, saying that his only concern is to empower leadership that responds to the people. "The next step is to inspire the Ugandan people to speak up and fight for freedom in their country," he told me.

But his political allies are less equivocal. "Actually, our plan is that we should start pushing this government out now," said DP President Norbert Mao.

"[Museveni] has been here for thirty-something years," Kato said. "He has done some good stuff that I don't want to ignore. But you don't want to only look at the few things we have done well. This guy came into power by the gun, so I don't think somebody can just change. He has failed to have a fair, civil conversation."

Many of Kampala's youth would agree, and the opposition is looking to harness this energy.

"We definitely have got to confront the regime," Mao told me. "The people cannot wait for a timetable prescribed by Museveni."

“Heroin Pills, Blood Money”

Yale Stays Silent on Ties to a Big Pharma Family

BY **VANESSA ZHANG**

DOWNTOWN NEW HAVEN, 2008. Nobel laureates and esteemed university professors mill about in the lobby of a large Yale research building. Standing in the center of the foyer is an unassuming man, frail and wearing thick-framed glasses, who shies away from the handshakes.

At age 88, Raymond Sackler had amassed wealth that would have made the Vanderbilts green-eyed: his family’s net worth now stands at 13 billion dollars. The ceremony honored Sackler’s multimillion-dollar gift, which established the Raymond and Beverly Sackler Institute for Biological, Physical and Engineering Sciences at Yale University.

Yale School of Medicine Dean Robert Alpern recognized the Sacklers’ “commitment to advancing science” as “impressive and inspiring.” But Alpern did not mention the more contentious element of the Sacklers’ legacy: their role in the opioid crisis, which many

doctors and advocates believe began when the Sacklers' company, Purdue Pharma LP, started misleadingly marketing dangerous opioid painkillers in the late 1990s.

The Sackler family's public image is caught in a tug-of-war between its philanthropic generosity and its role in initiating the opioid crisis. As evidence of the family's charitable giving, the Sackler name is inscribed in a Yale institute and two endowed professorships. But unlike another Yale institution whose name has been questioned and changed—Grace Hopper College, which was named after slavery advocate and Vice President John C. Calhoun (YC 1804) until 2017—the Sacklers' gift has gone largely unnoticed, despite the family's divisive legacy.

Few Yale students know who the Sacklers are, let alone criticize their controversial business. Patrick Radden Keefe LAW '05, the *New Yorker* staff writer who investigated the family's links to the opioid crisis in October 2017, believes the silence may be related to the Sacklers' donor potential. "Perhaps it's because the Sacklers, unlike the Calhoun family, still have a fortune to give away," he wrote in his article.

Yet the consequences of the Sackler family's misdeeds continue today: 49,000 people died in 2017 alone from opioid abuse.

PURDUE PHARMA LP has built an empire revolving around pain management medication, branding itself a "pioneer in developing medications for reducing pain, a principal cause of human suffering." Its website is filled with images of smiling patients and physicians; the top of the screen reads, in bold white lettering, "a positive impact."

But there is a dark side to Purdue's pain pills. Released by Purdue in 1996, the drug OxyContin was approved by the Food and Drug Administration to treat "moderate to severe pain." Now, it is infamous as one of the key causes of opioid drug abuse. Mike Moore, a former Mississippi attorney general who is leading a new, multi-state suit against Purdue, told *The Politic* in an interview that in its advertising, the company "minimized the dangers of addiction, which was one of the major causes of this opioid epidemic."

"They're essentially heroin pills," Andrew Kolodny, co-director of the Opioid Policy Research Collaborative at Brandeis University, told *The Politic*.

According to Kolodny, heroin and oxycodone, the active ingredient in OxyContin, produce indistinguishable effects on the brain. After becoming addicted to prescribed OxyContin, patients often transition to non-prescription drugs like heroin and the even-deadlier fentanyl—another opioid 100 times more potent than morphine—when physicians discontinue their prescriptions.

When Purdue released OxyContin in 1996, it simultaneously launched a multifaceted campaign to misinform the medical community about opioids' risks, Kolodny said.

Purdue hired prominent pain specialists to exaggerate the problem of untreated chronic pain and to overstate the supposed benefits of using opioids

Over 200,000 Americans have died from overdoses related to misusing OxyContin and other prescription opioids since 2002.

to treat patients' pain. The American Pain Society, which received large donations from Purdue, published research supporting the use of opioids to treat pain of all severities. And as physicians bought into the campaign, the prescription of opioids soared into today's public health catastrophe.

Over 200,000 Americans have died from overdoses related to the misuse of OxyContin and other prescription opioids since 2002. Four in five people who try heroin today have previously used prescription painkillers, and 115 Americans die each day from opioid overdoses.

"The Sackler greed led to tremendous pain and suffering and loss of life," Kolodny said. "They created a very expensive problem in some communities. They're running out of money for caskets. The medical examiners and coroners are quitting because they can't handle the workload of opioid-abuse deaths."

Moore also stressed the massive scope of the opioid problem.

"Let's just say 100 opioid pills should have been sold to the country," he said. "Purdue Pharma marketed and sold, instead, 100,000 opioid pills."

Purdue Pharma is still privately owned by the Sackler family, but the family consistently avoids publicizing its connection to the business. No member of the immediate Sackler family holds executive positions today, although eight Sackler family members sit on the company's board. Richard Sackler served as Purdue's president from 1999 to 2003, when OxyContin sales were at their peak.

"The Sackler family owns this company," Moore explained. "I can promise you, if I owned a company and was making billions of dollars, I think I would probably know a little bit about it and about what was going on with my number one blockbuster drug."

Raymond and his older brother Mortimer grew up in Brooklyn in a middle-class family. They trained as physicians and later developed what has become one of the world's most successful pharmaceutical companies. *Forbes* reported in 2016 that the Sacklers were the nineteenth richest family in America. Their net worth of 13 billion dollars puts them ahead of some of America's most famous families, including the Rockefellers and the Mellons.

In 2007, Purdue paid 600 million dollars in one of the largest lawsuits ever against a pharmaceutical firm. Three of its top executives, none of whom were Sacklers, were found guilty of misinforming physicians and government officials of the drug's addictive potential.

"They're running out of money for caskets."

NINE YEARS AFTER Yale established the Sackler Institute, it renamed Calhoun College. The Committee to Establish Principles on Renaming determined that no Yale building should bear the name of John C. Calhoun, whose principal legacy is his fervent promotion of slavery. This set a precedent for future cases in which a namesake's legacy conflicts with the university's values.

Lynne Regan, a professor emeritus of biochemistry and former director of the Sackler Institute, told *Esquire* journalist Christopher Glazek '07 GRD '07 last year that neither students nor faculty have ever brought up the OxyContin connection.

"Most people don't know about that," she said in the interview. "I think people are mainly oblivious."

In contrast, Nic Muñoz MED '20, who leads the Addiction Medicine Collaborative, told *The Politic* that he has heard professors criticize Purdue Pharma.

"Purdue Pharma's been mentioned as a link in the progression [of] our current opioid epidemic and a poster child of the consequences of the intense marketing by pharmaceutical companies on provider prescribing," he said.

Even though some Yale faculty members feel comfortable condemning Purdue Pharma in the classroom, they have been more hesitant in conversations about the Sackler family, particularly in public.

The Politic reached out to Charles Fuchs, MD, MPH, who holds the Richard Sackler and Jonathan Sackler professorship, for comment on the Sacklers' relation to the opioid epidemic but instead received an email from Thomas Conroy, director of Yale's Office of Public Affairs and Communications, with a press statement on Yale's research combating the opioid crisis. The email did not mention the Sackler family's connection to the opioid crisis. Of the 28 administrators and professors *The Politic* contacted for interviews, including two that hold Sackler professorships, not one gave comment.

Kolodny believes that if the university wants to help "families who have been affected" by the opioid crisis, "Yale should give the money back to the Sacklers."

Kolodny added, "It's blood money."

UN FREEDOM OF THE PRESS

A War on Journalists in Mexico

BY **JAKE LEFFEW**

"So Many Journalists Have Been Killed in Mexico This Year That a Newspaper is Shutting Down," *The Washington Post*, 2017.

RECENT VICTIMS

Carlos Domínguez Rodríguez
Killed on January 13, 2018
Stabbed to death on a road.

Gumaro Pérez Aguilando
Killed on December 19, 2017
Shot to death at son's school.

Édgar D. E. Castro
Killed on October 6, 2017
Abducted and later found dead.

IMAGES COURTESY OF **REPORTERS WITHOUT BORDERS**

Just after 7 a.m. on February 5, 2014, Gregorio Jiménez de la Cruz, a crime reporter in the eastern coastal state of Veracruz, Mexico, was *dragged* from his home and *tortured*—*his body tossed in a mass grave*. Law enforcement quickly detained six suspects: five armed men who ambushed Jiménez and a woman who said she'd put the hit on him because of a personal dispute, according to Mexican news reports. *But Jiménez's family said the murder was retaliation against his reporting*.

JIMÉNEZ WAS A TRAGIC CASUALTY of Mexico's war of attrition on journalists. Last year, Mexico ranked just behind Syria and Iraq—both international warzones—as the most fatal country in the world for the press, according to the Committee to Protect Journalists. In Veracruz, violence against the press spiked in 2010 due to a corrupt governorship and a turf war between rival cartels. Israel Hernández, a young reporter and Veracruz native, said in an interview there was "an epidemic of assassinations" in his state.

But violence against the press is not just a problem in Veracruz. Work conditions for journalists have deteriorated across the country. Since 2000, more than 100 journalists have been killed. At least 39 of those murders were due to their work, according to the Committee to Protect Journalists.

And this year shows no sign of improvement: at least three journalists have died in 2018 in connection to their coverage.

The 21st century has heralded an increasingly complicated era for the press in Mexico. When journalists served as the mouthpiece of the ruling Partido Revolucionario Institucional (PRI), which monopolized politics from 1929 to 2000, antipress violence was rare. Now, while journalists are more investigative than before, reporting is more dangerous than ever. The problem is rooted in Mexico's broken judicial system, rampant narco violence, and corrupt local bosses, according to journalists, academics, and press freedom advocates. Journalists—especially those in conflict-prone areas—describe the feeling of wading through a minefield: one misstep—offend the wrong person, ask too many questions—and you, too, may find yourself in a mass grave.

Following Jiménez's death in 2014, some journalists, including Hernández, protested the low pay, regular harassment, and murders they faced. Their efforts gained little traction. Hernández was among the most outspoken, and he started to receive threats. He got mysterious phone calls at work and saw strange men taking photographs of his house.

"At any time," he said, "it could be any one of us for whatever reason."

ON DECEMBER 16, 2005, Lydia Cacho was arrested in Cancún by at least ten men who threw her in the back of a van. Some were police officers, and the others were private security agents for Mexican textile tycoon José Kamel Nacif Borge. Cacho's kidnapping would soon become a national scandal and the subject of international condemnation. Her story, published in a recent report by the United Nations Commission on Human Rights, shows that journalists face threats not only from criminal organizations, but from public officials and businessmen, too.

A few months before her kidnapping, Cacho published a book titled *The Demons of Eden: The Power That Protects Child Pornography*, which exposed the pattern of sexual abuse in Cancún that was protected by politicians, law enforcement, and businessmen. Cacho named Nacif in the book as the friend of the leader of a child pornography ring. Nacif, who resides in the southern state of Puebla, filed suit against Cacho

"In Mexico, 'It's Easy to Kill a Journalist,'" *The New York Times*, 2017.

for defamation and slander.

The author was arrested in Cancún and was driven 20 hours to Puebla. During the car ride, she was not allowed to eat or sleep. One of the police officers shoved his pistol into her mouth, making semi-circular motions and sexually explicit comments. He forced open her legs and pointed the weapon at her genitals.

Cacho was released on bail days later. In an article published in the popular Mexican daily *La Jornada* on December 21, 2005, Nacif admitted that he colluded with the governor of his state, Mario Marín. "I pleaded with the governor that this woman was slandering me and he told me, 'Here no one is being slandered' and—boom!—they issued the arrest warrant," he told the paper. In February 2006, *La Jornada* and a Mexican radio station released the content of phone calls in which Marín and Nacif discussed Cacho's arrest.

"Yesterday I finished hitting that old bitch over the fucking head," Marín said in a phone call. "I told her that in Puebla, the law is respected and there is no impunity and whoever commits a crime will be called a delinquent." Nacif called Marín "the hero of the movie" and promised two bottles of cognac for his help.

Cacho's case raced to the Mexican Supreme Court, which ruled that her liberty had not been violated. But in July 2018, the United Nations Commission on Human Rights condemned Mexico for its treatment of Cacho. For press freedom activists, the decision validated a common complaint: the state was part of the problem. But journalists say it is unlikely the UN resolution will do much to change the reality of their situation.

I MET ONE OF MEXICO'S top reporters, Alejandra Xanic von Bertrab, in a café on a cloudy August afternoon in Mexico City. Xanic, as she is called, helped lay a foundation for investigative journalism in the 1990s, when the country's press was almost entirely co-opted by the PRI. She has seen journalists in Mexico become more independent and assertive than ever.

In 1992, after snooping around the site of a gas leak in Guadalajara, Xanic got her first major scoop. She saw a meter on a machine that read 100 percent "*explosividad*" and filed a story with a sketch of the danger zone for a paper the next morning, April 22. Hours later, five miles of the street exploded, leveling the neighborhood and killing hundreds. Xanic's report was prescient, and she covered the fallout of the explosion for more than a year. Her reporting was a milestone for the Mexican press—a rare example of a local newspaper challenging the state's narrative on a national story.

"In order to serve the public, we had to have a very different relationship with power," she said. "There's such a long tradition of another relationship—one where the reporters were dependent, submissive, and took orders."

Xanic, writing for *The New York Times* in 2013, helped uncover how Walmart de México had bribed public officials to alter zoning procedures in a corrupt effort to build a store near the ancient Aztec ruins at Teotihuacán. Along with her co-writer David Barstow, Xanic won a Pulitzer Prize for the report, making her the first Mexican woman to win the award for investigative reporting.

In recent years, Xanic said, the press has become more aggressive. An important change came under President Vicente Fox (2000-2006), who established an information request system similar to that provided by the U.S. Freedom of Information Act. Prior to the reform, "the only public information was the phone book," she said. After, journalists could access official documents on atrocities and corruption, expanding reporters' access to information for decades to come.

BUT COVERAGE THAT CHALLENGES power can trigger violent backlash—as Steve Fisher, a freelance journalist from western Pennsylvania, recently learned the hard way.

Fisher, for the *Los Angeles Times*, was covering a dicey topic: Mexican soldiers who were growing frustrated with the direction of the war on drugs. He knew of the Mexican government's spying capabilities, so he was cautious when communicating with sources. He used burner phones and encrypted apps to talk to Oswaldo Ortega, a disgruntled former military police officer who spoke on the record about the conflict.

Fisher traveled outside of Mexico City to interview Ortega. But an hour before their scheduled meeting, Ortega called Fisher to say that he had been kidnapped by a group of armed men. Ortega believed them to be from the state prosecutor's office. Ortega was held for hours, waterboarded, and tortured with electro-shocks to the testicles by the captors who specifically asked why he wanted to talk to Steve Fisher.

Fisher believed the captors meant to intimidate him by using his name. "They knew exactly what they were doing using my full name," he said. "They said [to Ortega], 'If you ever meet with this journalist again, your family will find your body cut in two on the side of a highway.'"

DESPITE FISHER'S SCARE, it is rare that American correspondents, with the security of a United States passport, or high-profile journalists like Xanic are harassed or killed. Local reporters, like Israel Hernández from Veracruz, face the greatest risk.

Hernández began studying at the University of Veracruz in 2009, dreaming of becoming a journalist at a time when there was not so much violence against the press. But in 2010, he said, two major things changed: Javier Duarte de Ochoa started his corrupt governorship and a gruesome turf war began between two of Mexico's most ruthless cartels. By 2017, according to the nongovernmental organization Reporters Without Borders, Veracruz was the deadliest area in the Western Hemisphere for journalists.

"Three Mexican Film Students Were Killed, Their Bodies Dissolved in Acid, Authorities Say," *The Washington Post*, 2018.

In 2014, the same year as Gregorio Jiménez de la Cruz's death, Hernández began to investigate the kidnappings of at least ten young men, some of whom were accused of being petty thieves. After a year of reporting, Hernández published the article, "Where are the disappeared, Artúro Bermúdez?" in a Veracruz news blog, referencing the Veracruz public security secretary. Bermúdez is now under criminal investigation for his role in the dozens of disappearances that occurred during his tenure.

Sourcing from victims' family and friends, Hernández pieced together a story that indicated the young men were taken by state police officers who terrorized the neighborhood. One of the teenagers was even dragged from his room. The article was the product of tireless investigation, and was also a lamentation of Hernández's wounded home.

"Historically, Veracruz has always been a violent city—since its founding by the Spanish in 1519, the blood has not stopped running," he wrote.

Soon after the report was published, Hernández left Mexico to study journalism at a university in Spain. In August 2015, he returned to Veracruz just days after his friend and colleague Rubén Espinosa was tortured and executed in an apartment in Mexico City. Hernández found a note on his car that that contained personal information about him and his wife, as well as private conversations they'd had.

"I realized they had tapped my phone," Hernández said, still unsure who "they" were. "I understood the message. It told me that this was bad."

JOURNALISTS IN MEXICO often express a deep mistrust for the government, despite the state's alleged efforts to curb violence against the press.

In 2010, President Felipe Calderon's administration created a special prosecutors office for crimes against freedom of expression, known by its Spanish acronym, FEADLE. But after eight years of FEADLE-led investigations, the impunity rate for crimes against the press is almost 100 percent. (The national impunity rate for all crimes is 93 percent.) The few countries with worse records of convicting those who commit crimes against journalists include Iraq, Syria, and Somalia, according to the Committee to Protect Journalists.

"With Iraq, [impunity] is a war problem," said Jan-Albert Hootsen, Mexico's representative on the Committee to Protect Journalists. He said that in Mexico, however, it is the product of "out of control criminal violence, a completely dysfunctional justice state, and a staggering lack of interest by the Mexican state to seriously address the problem of attacks against the press."

Hootsen explained that impunity begins the moment a journalist is assaulted or killed. Emergency phone calls are often not taken and police sometimes show up hours late to a crime scene. Evidence collecting is weak and materials can be contaminated. The outcome is almost always the same: the perpetrator goes free and the crimes continue.

In 2012, under pressure from civil society and the international community, the Mexican government established the Federal Protection Mechanism of Human Rights Defenders and Journalists, which provides journalists in danger with panic buttons, bodyguards, and other security measures. Many states followed with their own systems. According to Hootsen, the mechanism does help some, but many are reluctant to turn to the government for protection when roughly half of all aggressions against the press stem from public officials.

"All these new institutions—the mechanism, federal prosecutors, federal statutes—all these new tools and we have more attacks," said Javier Garza, former editor of the regional newspaper *El Siglo de Torreón*. In 2010, when Garza was editor, the city of Torreón became a battlefield for the Sinaloa cartel and Zetas. More than once, the newspaper's office was shot at and set on fire; multiple reporters were murdered and others kidnapped.

Still, Garza emphasized public corruption as a major source of anti-press violence. He said: "Coordinating with the state governments on policies to help journalists is like putting the wolf in charge of the henhouse."

THE SPECTER OF DEATH haunts many reporters, who are now forced to adjust to their new reality. Self-censorship is one way journalists protect themselves. In a survey of more than 300 journalists, researchers found nearly 70 percent of respondents have not published something for fear of retaliation. Another way is through organizations like Periodistas de a Pie, which host forums on covering conflict zones and raise awareness for victims of violence.

Arturo Contreras is a 28-year-old reporter at Periodistas de a Pie, where he works as an investigative journalist. Contreras wears round glasses and his hair brushes his shoulders when he walks; he can quote German sociologist Max Weber in conversation without missing a beat. He also recently published a report that revealed dozens of cases in which innocent people had been kidnapped, raped, or murdered over many years by the police in Mexico City.

"I would love to write about art and music," Contreras said. "But I think there are more necessary things to be done."

Contreras is based in Mexico City, which makes him feel more comfortable than if he was in, say, Veracruz. In a capital city of roughly nine million, he is less likely to be hunted.

But journalists in Mexico are still harassed daily, and many are killed. The country's rampant impunity, criminal violence, and public corruption makes some reporters feel as though they are tiptoeing around death.

"Either you can live a normal life, but not do a real journalistic job," Contreras said. **"Or you can die trying."**

COURTESY OF **NPR**

"OMBUDSMAN OF THE ROOM"

An Interview with Jake Tapper

BY **PETER ROTHPLETZ**

Jake Tapper is the chief Washington correspondent for CNN. He anchors both a weekday television news show, *The Lead with Jake Tapper*, and the Sunday morning current affairs program, *State of the Union*. Prior to joining CNN, Tapper served as the senior White House correspondent for ABC News and a national correspondent for Salon.com. His reporting has been published in *The New York Times, The Washington Post*, and *The Weekly Standard*, among other publications.

***THE POLITIC*: DO YOU THINK THERE IS A HISTORICAL PRECEDENT FOR THE RISE OF TRUMP AND TRUMPISM? SOME HAVE TOSSED AROUND COMPARISONS TO BARRY GOLDWATER, RICHARD NIXON, AND EVEN JOE MCCARTHY. ARE ANY OF THOSE EXAMPLES APPROPRIATE? IS THERE A PERIOD THAT AMERICANS CAN LOOK BACK TO FOR WISDOM?**

JAKE TAPPER: It's been said that history doesn't repeat itself, but it rhymes, and whether you are reading about McCarthy or Nixon or Bill Clinton, there's a lot of rhyming. I don't know that there's any particular president or politician that is exactly the same as President Trump. There are certainly shades of overlap, and President Trump didn't invent lying or smearing. He just takes it to a new level that we haven't seen in presidents probably ever before. His supporters often say that he's just punching back; he's just counter-punching. A lot of times that's true, but we have also been in a country where, for the most part, United States presidents don't lower themselves to respond to as many criticisms as President Trump does or to attack as personally as he does.

I think Trump and Trumpism is a manifestation of many different parts of American popular cultural and societal evolution, including the increasing importance of celebrity, the lack of faith in experts, the populist distrust of intellectualism, the moral compromises made by supporters of Bill Clinton. I think today you see Evangelicals making compromises about President Trump similar to how in the '90s we saw feminists making compromises about Bill Clinton. He and his personal behavior were reprehensible to everything that they stood for in terms of feminism, but by the same token, was

"It was an introduction to journalism where Washington appeared to be in many ways a town replete with hypocrites and liars...I would be naïve to say it didn't have a tremendous influence on how I look at a lot of politicians."

taking many feminist, progressive, capital D Democratic actions. ... The same can be said when it comes to President Trump with conservative Evangelical Christians.

I think Trumpism is a phenomenon that bears a dozen fathers, and he's not just a descendent of McCarthy or Nixon or Bill Clinton or whomever. Although, as you know, there is specific connective tissue with Joe McCarthy, in the sense that Joe McCarthy's protegé was Roy Cohn and Roy Cohn's protegé was Donald Trump.

YOU FIRST STARTED WORKING AS A JOURNALIST SHORTLY BEFORE PRESIDENT CLINTON'S IMPEACHMENT PROCEEDINGS. YOU'VE ALSO BEEN VERY OPEN ABOUT HOW YOU KNEW MONICA LEWINSKY PRIOR TO THE SCANDAL BREAKING. HOW DO YOU THINK THAT EPISODE SHAPED YOU AS A JOURNALIST?

It was very influential on me as a journalist. I saw the media and the Democratic Party from a different perspective than a lot of other reporters. Bill Clinton took advantage of a young intern who worked for him. The behavior was indefensible, and lying about it was reprehensible.

My perspective was [that] this was a young woman who didn't deserve this. I couldn't believe that President Clinton would take...I mean I believed it. But I was astounded and shocked and revulsed that President Clinton took advantage of her given that I knew her and knew how personally vulnerable I think she was at that age. And I didn't think it was a joke. At the same time, a lot of the people in the Republican House who were professing horror at what Bill Clinton did had done the same exact thing.

It was an introduction to journalism where Washington appeared to be in many ways a town replete with hypocrites and liars, and I think I would be naïve to say it didn't have a tremendous influence on how I look at a lot of politicians.

CNN'S KAITLAN COLLINS WAS EXCLUDED FROM A WHITE HOUSE PRESS EVENT AFTER ASKING PRESIDENT TRUMP A NUMBER OF QUESTIONS DURING A JULY PHOTO OP WITH THE PRESIDENT OF THE EUROPEAN COMMISSION. SEVERAL OUTLETS, INCLUDING FOX NEWS, CAME TO MS. COLLINS' DEFENSE AND CRITICIZED THE ADMINISTRATION'S MOVE. AS A FORMER WHITE HOUSE CORRESPONDENT, CAN YOU SPEAK TO THE CAMARADERIE IN THE PRESS CORPS? HOW HAS IT EVOLVED UNDER TRUMP?

The White House press corps is a very competitive environment, and it's especially challenging because you want to be aggressively covering the White House but you also want to be getting scoops from administration officials. Sometimes those two things are at odds. If you are the most aggressive reporter in the press corps, the chances that you will be getting scoops diminish because people will not want to help you. And if you follow individual reporters' work, you can see some try to get as many scoops as possible while others try to throw punches—and that's in any White House.

That said, I do think the White House press corps needs to band together more. We can't let presidents and press secretaries play us off each other—by not answering that guy's question and using this woman's question as a way of deflecting by calling on somebody else. We should be following up each other's questions and standing up for each other. I tried to do that while I was in the White House press corps. One time I followed up on a reporter's question that I didn't think that President Obama had answered and he mockingly called me the "ombudsman of the room." And I tried to stand up for colleagues

who worked for Fox News channel when the Obama White House was trying to label the entire Fox News channel as not a legitimate news organization...and certainly I have my issues with plenty of hosts and things that are aired on that channel, but at the time I knew of some really good reporters who worked there—Major Garrett especially at the time. So I tried to do some of that; it's not easy to do. And the more we see the better.

I saw some of it after what happened to Kaitlan Collins. Now, some of that occured because Kaitlan came from conservative media, as before she was at CNN she was at the Daily Caller, so it was more difficult for people to label her some left-winger, which she isn't obviously. But it was good to see people banding around her. But that said, there's not enough of it. And there needs to be more of it. There needs to be more solidarity and collegiality. But I do think this press corps has shown more of it than I've seen in a long time.

I'M CURIOUS HOW YOU WOULD COMPARE YOUR MORE HEATED EXCHANGES WITH FORMER WHITE HOUSE PRESS SECRETARY ROBERT GIBBS TO THOSE BETWEEN SARAH HUCKABEE SANDERS AND YOUR CONTEMPORARIES?

It's different because the level of prevarication that comes out of this White House is so astounding. Gibbs and I had very heated exchanges, and I can't speak for him, but certainly if I could go back...It's not like I wouldn't do things a little bit differently, but that said, the issues that I pushed on I think were legitimate issues to push on. And as a general note, I think we are in that room to challenge these people, to challenge the government. You're making decisions that affect the lives of hundreds of millions of people, and those questions should be asked. I really don't think one can compare my tough exchanges with Gibbs, or David Gregory's tough exchanges with Ari Fleischer, to today's interactions. It's a different era. Sarah Sanders really doesn't seem to like reporters very much, she doesn't do the briefing very often anymore, and this White House just says a lot of things that are not true. Other White Houses have said things that aren't true too, but, again, the sheer velocity and number of lies is staggering.

FOR SOME TIME NOW, YOU HAVEN'T HESITATED TO DESCRIBE PRESIDENT TRUMP'S FALSE STATEMENTS AS LIES. GENERALLY SPEAKING, JOURNALISTS HAVE BEEN RELUCTANT TO USE THAT LABEL. WHY DID YOU DECIDE TO START USING IT?

Saying someone is lying suggests that he or she knows what he or she is saying is false. It gets to intent. Sometimes journalists give someone the benefit of the doubt and judge the statement as false without getting into intent. But sometimes the falsehoods are so brazen or so repeated that it would be a dereliction of journalistic duty to grant a benefit of the doubt.

GRAHAM VYSE OF *THE NEW REPUBLIC* PROFILED YOU BACK IN MARCH, AND HE ASSERTS THROUGHOUT THE PIECE THAT ALMOST EVERYONE, REGARDLESS OF THEIR POLITICAL LEANINGS, LIKES JAKE TAPPER. WHY DO YOU THINK THAT IS?

Well, I don't think that is. I don't think that is. It was a kind piece. I think there are a lot of people who don't like me or who dislike the work I do. And that's okay.

While making clear that I do not agree with that premise, I do think that I aspire to be fair, and I aspire to understand all points of view whether they come from the progressive-Bernie Sanders-Alexandria Ocasio-Cortez-Left or the Ben Sasse-Jeff Flake-Right or the Donald Trump-whatever-that-is. Because it's not exactly conservatism. It's its own kind of political ideology.

But that said, the Trump era has been a time for people in the media to stand for and defend the notion of empirical fact and the notion of truth and to point out behavior, when it's appropriate, that is not decent, such as mocking somebody with a disability.

I don't agree with the premise, but to the extent that it's true, that's why I suppose it's true. I mean, believe me, if you read my Twitter feed, and I don't anymore, you would see that this is not a world full of 100-percent Tapper lovers.

"THERE NEEDS TO BE MORE SOLIDARITY AND COLLEGIALITY."

Road to
A New Memorial Recal

IN MONTGOMERY, THE HEAT is as brutal as the rumors say. "Texas-hot" is how a family friend described summer in Alabama when she learned that my father and I were to spend a weekend together down there. From almost any place in the U.S., Montgomery is "down there," except from a few other states in the South, who see Alabama eye to eye. "Fried-egg-hot" is what Brian, a chatty Uber driver with an ash-brown goatee and a golden cross pendant hanging down his sunburned chest, called the weather in his home state. When my father and I dropped off our car for servicing by our hotel one Saturday morning in early August, it was Brian who picked us up in his black F-150 and spirited us into downtown Montgomery. A few minutes into the drive, Brian, a "God-fearing man," according to his Uber profile, mentioned that we smelled like cigarettes. I told him that the Sleep Inn we booked still allows guests to smoke indoors. "Rules must be different down here," my father added quietly. Brian just nodded and continued to discuss the heat.

Crucial to understanding why I was speeding west on I-85 in the backseat of Brian's Ford pickup with my father, and why I was willing to travel the 1,574-mile round trip from my home in southern Maryland to central Alabama and back, is what, exactly, I was seeking in the South. The short answer is simple: the National Memorial for Peace and Justice had opened in Montgomery a few months prior to our trip. The memorial serves to remember the black victims killed by white lynch mobs in America between 1877 and 1950, and my father and I, white men from Maryland, wished to see it. That much I did know.

The long answer is more elusive. I knew that the memorial was the beginning of a new sort of remembering and the end of an older, more selective sort, and that somewhere along that spectrum was the place I am most deeply invested in: southern Maryland, the part of the South I have always called home. It was that investment that put my father and me on the I-95 corridor in my white Chevy Impala last summer. We steered through county after Southern county, our wheels devouring the asphalt until we reached a spot in western Georgia, just before the Alabama line, and hit some traffic. The Alannah Myles song "Black Velvet" began playing through the radio. We slowed to a crawl. As Myles hummed the song's intro, I thought mostly of the home hundreds of miles behind me, and of how the story would only make sense if I started there, where I had been raised, and where a black man whose name I had never heard before was lynched and forgotten more than a century ago. But by then, dusk was approaching, and Montgomery was still eighty miles away, so I rested my eyes and listened to Myles sing us there.

Mississippi in the middle of a dry spell
Jimmy Rodgers on the Victrola up high
Mama's dancin' with baby on her shoulder
The sun is settin' like molasses in the sky

SOUTHERN MARYLAND IS a region stolen from swampland, a place where herons nest and breed, and where the market price of blue crabs serves the same conversational purpose that the cost of gasoline does elsewhere. The low-lying coastal plain that defines this area appears to bleed into the western shore of the Chesapeake Bay, its major arteries being the Patuxent, which divides Calvert and St. Mary's Counties; and the Potomac, which curls around Charles County and traces Maryland's southern border past Washington, D.C., winding north through the Piedmont's gentle hills, snaking between the pine-dotted slopes of western Maryland and into Appalachia.

Today the Potomac River serves the same purpose the Mason-Dixon Line once fulfilled: it divides the North from the South, attempts to keep Virginia and its sisters below separate from New England and the Mid-Atlantic in maps and minds. These lines become smudged in Maryland. The true cultural divide lies somewhere below Annapolis, the state's capital, and roils like boiling water in a pot. Southern Maryland sits just below the surface

Southern Maryland is both familiar and alien to me in the way only one's

Montgomery

lls a Maryland Lynching

BY T.C. MARTIN

home can be. I have lived my entire life there and know its particulars well: I know that you should go early to the breakfast buffet at St. Mary's Landing on Sundays before the post-church rush, and I know that the town of La Plata, where I attended high school, was incorporated in 1888 when the railroad came through. I also know that there are local narratives concealed from my neighbors and me, histories willfully forgotten because nobody wanted to remember them. (My family has lived there long enough that one, if not several, of my ancestors were probably instrumental in the forgetting.) These dark stories lurk in census records and newspaper archives, waiting to be dragged into the sunlit present and told. One of these stories is the lynching of Benjamin Hance.

Little is known about Hance's origins. He was born around 1865, near the end of the Civil War, and by his fifteenth birthday he had found his way to the village of Leonardtown in St. Mary's County. There he was hired by Henry Mattingley, a single white oysterman about nine years his senior. Life on the water may have suited Hance; at the time of his death in 1887, he was still employed as a deckhand, having been hired by Captain Frank Russell sometime after working for Mattingley. Much of this information is recorded in the 1880 census, the only public record of Hance's existence I could find aside from the newspaper coverage of his murder. When I peered at the handwritten census sheet, I imagined a fifteen-year-old Hance staring back, frozen in his youth by bureaucratic scrawl.

Whether Hance had any family in southern Maryland, or in Virginia, where he resided at the time of his death, is unclear. The victim's relationships, his friendships, the people who held him dear: these were not the sort of details reported by newspapers, even those newspapers that most strongly condemned the injustice.

The part of Hance's life which most interested the papers—his death—began at the old Leonardtown jail, a stout two-story building which still stands on the corner of Court House Drive and an unnamed back lane near the center of

the town. It shares a large lawn with the St. Mary's County Circuit Court, an imposing brick structure with four stately white columns guarding its façade.

PHOTO BY T.C. MARTIN

I had seen the old jail before, but I had not consciously noticed it, nor had I known its role in Hance's lynching. In the five years preceding Hance's murder, six other black Marylanders were lynched. Among them was a man named Charles Whitley. A year before Hance's death, a white mob hanged Whitley from a persimmon tree in Calvert County. Some newspapers claimed that Hance's lynching was unexpected, as it was the first to take place in St. Mary's County. But the county lines dividing southern Maryland are largely formalities. Calvert's shoreline is visible to almost any observer on the St. Mary's side of the Patuxent, even before the morning river fog dissipates. Gossip travels quickly over water there.

Hance's lynching did not take place at the jail as it often does in these stories, but it almost did. On the night of May 27, 1887, Hance was arrested and charged with the attempted assault of a white woman named Alice Bailey. Hance was held in the jail for three weeks while awaiting trial. It was still dark outside when, on the morning of June 17, a white mob broke into the jail and kidnapped Hance. The mob planned to hang him from a locust tree on the shared lawn of the courthouse and the old jail. John T. Spalding, a white man whose property abutted the courthouse, requested that the mob find someplace else, so as not disturb his wife's delicate disposition. The mob complied.

I visited the grounds of the old jail one afternoon this summer when the earth was baking and the air was damp, and when even the anxious honeybees seemed subdued in a tropic stupor. I walked the perimeter of the building and regarded a corroded cannon that had been salvaged from one of the first English ships to arrive in Maryland. Also preserved on the lawn was a boulder the size and shape of an overstuffed pillow. Known as the Moll Dyer Rock, it is said to have been found in 1697 near the body of Moll Dyer, the subject of Maryland's most infamous witch trial legend. As I knelt down to inspect the rock more closely, I noticed that its surface pulsated with thousands of crawling black ants.

There were other items around the jail, among them a wooden bench resting in the shade of one large tree and an unpainted picnic table sitting beneath another. The air smelled heady, like the cheery yellow daffodils that ringed the seating area. The site would be ideal for a family picnic, were it not for the constant wondering, the tense involuntary glances cast toward the treetops. And the questions: *How do I identify a locust tree? Can such a tree survive for more than a hundred years? Was Hance almost murdered here, right where I am sitting?*

But these queries were mine. The tension, the anxious wondering: mine. No family picnicking outside the jail would be reminded of Hance's lynching, because no reminder exists there. This is unsurprising. Lynchings are not often part of the history that Southern towns devote themselves to remembering, especially on the lawns of their most beloved institution: the courthouse.

The courthouse building loomed over me as I sat on the bench taking notes and swatting mosquitoes away from my arms. Four or five white boys, maybe ten years old, raced through a nearby parking lot on brightly colored, superhero-themed bicycles, their laughter chiming like delicate bells. They paid no mind to the old jail. It occurred to me that if those boys were to visit the jail one day, what they would find is not an acknowledgment of the injustice done to Hance, but the pieces of the past that their ancestors and mine most wanted to remember: a rusty cannon and a rock covered in ants.

THE MOB STRAPPED HANCE to a horse and rode a mile or so out of town, past farms and homes and over a plank bridge, until they found a witch-hazel tree that swung out over the road. Hance was forced to stand on the roof of a buggy as a noose was fastened around his neck, fixed to a

tree branch, and tightened.

The mob pulled the buggy from beneath him, and Hance became in that moment something more and less than a person. He was not just a man anymore, but a symbol: a symbol of power, of extralegal privilege, of white supremacy's corporeal impact. But he also became a body left hanging—mutilated, denigrated. A reporter for the *St. Mary's Beacon* described Hance's body after the lynching as "a gruesome enough sight to satisfy any lover of horrors." The *Beacon* reader comprehends that the true purpose of the lynching was not justice, or at least not a justice of fairness and mercy. This justice was not meant to rectify wrongdoing, but to "satisfy" the angry white men battering down the jailhouse door, the men's white wives sleeping soundly in their beds, and their white children walking to school the morning after, who might happen upon a black body twisting in the wind, and stare.

The exact site of Hance's lynching is still unknown, but an aide at the St. Mary's County Historical Society directed me to the former site of the plank bridge, close to where Hance was hanged. The bridge stood near the intersection of MD-5 and Newtowne Neck Road and spanned McIntosh Run, a cool narrow creek that widens as it reaches the old Leonardtown wharf and flushes into the Potomac. The wooden bridge has since been replaced by a concrete one, which I have traveled over countless times in my life, unaware of its history. Today the intersection by the bridge features a small winery, a CVS pharmacy, and a McDonald's.

Hance's body was not retrieved until later that same morning, well after the sun had risen. He was buried in the cemetery of St. Aloysius Gonzaga Church, about a ten-minute drive north from the old Leonardtown jail. The church has since moved to a newer building downtown, but the cemetery remains at the earlier site.

I visited this small, verdant plot of land the day after Independence Day. The cemetery sits at the end of a narrow residential road and catches the driver by surprise. There are fewer than a hundred graves at the site, and they are bisected by a dirt driveway just wide enough for a single car. At first, it seemed to me that the cemetery received few, if any, visitors. The headstones were crumbling, cracked, and coated with thick layers of moss and lichen. Most of the people buried there were born shortly before 1900 and died in the mid-20th century, although several inscriptions show birth dates prior to the Civil War and death dates as recent as 2008. St. Aloysius is not a pleasant place to visit in Maryland's July, when nature itself seems intent on keeping us indoors. Kamikaze swarms of tiny grasshopper-like insects dove at my ears, and I swiped them away with a sweat-soaked palm.

But mourners had been there not that long ago. I knew this because a half-dozen graves, although blanketed in moss, were adorned with petite Confederate flags, freshly planted and unstained.

If Hance was buried in the cemetery's central yard, his name was not on any of its headstones. His grave might be marked by a haphazard pile of jagged stones, or a slim stone pole leaning ten degrees off-center, or nothing. It does not seem unlikely that a black lynching victim might have been buried among the dense foliage surrounding the central yard, forever consigned to an invisible grave. That was the final tragedy visited upon Benjamin Hance: the forgetting.

TWENTY-NINE BLACK MEN were murdered by white mobs in Maryland between 1877 and 1950. These lynchings occurred not only in southern Maryland, but also on the Eastern Shore, an agrarian region that lies on the Delmarva Peninsula between the Chesapeake Bay and the Atlantic Ocean, and in western Maryland, which closely resembles Appalachia in landscape, politics, and speech.

But central Maryland, that well-populated tract that stretches from the Pennsylvania line down to Prince George's County and includes Baltimore, Annapolis, and the D.C. suburbs, is not without its own lynching narratives. In the college town of Westminster, in Carroll County, a man named Townsend Cook was killed two years before Hance's murder. Thirty miles north of Baltimore, in the town of Bel Air—which would chafe at the label "Southern"—Lewis Harris was lynched in 1900.

There were two reactions I came to expect in central Maryland when I told people I was researching local lynchings. Surprise was typical: Many people had no idea that such atrocious murders had occurred in their towns. Even the library aide at the Carroll County Historical Society seemed skeptical of my claim until we scrolled through the microfilm of one of the county's weekly papers. We eventually reached June 6, 1885, the first publication date after Cook's murder. The headline read plainly: "The Lynching of Cook."

Another common reaction concerned motive. At the Carroll County Historical Society, I met a local man who was stopping by to see a new Civil War exhibit. He had tan skin with a few shadows of wrinkles, and his jeans were broken-in and loose around the calf, so that they swished when he walked. The library aide mentioned that I was studying Cook's murder and asked if he knew of the lynching. The man said he didn't, then asked me: "What did he do?"

That question was asked in the same tone as another, this one by a friend's

I know that there are local narratives concealed from my neighbors and me, histories willfully forgotten because nobody wanted to remember them.

relative in Bel Air, where I was researching the Harris lynching: "Are you a Democrat?"

These questions were more straightforward than the ones I encountered at home, in southern Maryland. My grandmother, who lives nearby, would ask me how the research was going, and I would say it was going just fine. My parents, no doubt curious as to why their son was trekking back and forth to century-old crime scenes, asked me the same question separately, in their own oblique ways. The question was: What is the point of all this?

I suppose that is why I brought my father with me to Montgomery: to see the answer I did not yet know how to voice.

MY FATHER AND I arrived in Montgomery late in the night, when the city was asleep. The next day, it seemed reluctant to wake up. A warm breeze huffed along the empty streets lined with sun-bleached sidewalks and closed storefronts. Down near the bank of the murky Alabama River, where the old Montgomery Union Station still stands, the damp fetid air lingered overhead like chemicals in a house under fumigation. I could imagine the trains departing the city from the old station, but I could not picture them ever returning.

The only signs of life to be found were confined to a six-acre block enclosed by the streets Caroline, Clayton, Holcombe, and Mildred. On Google Maps, this land still appears vacant. Since April, however, it has been home to the National Memorial for Peace and Justice, the nation's first large-scale monument to the thousands of black victims of racial terror lynchings.

The memorial was founded by the Equal Justice Initiative (EJI), whose headquarters sit on Commerce Street in downtown Montgomery, sandwiched between the Hank Williams Museum and a sub shop. The EJI serves as a rallying point for combating racial and economic inequalities in the criminal justice system. The 24-year-old non-profit has sought to overturn wrongful convictions, argued against life sentences for children, and provided legal counsel for Alabamians being tried in death penalty cases.

Under the midday sun, the grounds of the memorial were stunningly bright. My father and I followed a gravel pathway past the street entrance and up the terraced mound from which the memorial seems to have sprouted. The path was well-trodden with the imprints of other visitors' shoes. Ahead of us, an older white couple ambled by a sculpture of an enslaved mother clutching her newborn to her chest, her face contorted in anguish. Farther ahead of them was a black family, six or seven adults with a similar number of children, all of them wearing purple family reunion T-shirts. The only sound was the crunching of gravel underfoot and our soft panting breath. The hill was steeper than it looked: you had to want to reach the top to get there.

We crested the hill. The air was cooler up there; a slight breeze blew from the direction of the Alabama State Capitol, whose pristine white dome was visible from the top of the hill. The memorial was too far away from the city's numerous Confederate monuments and landmarks for us to see them clearly—but they were there, in the distance, nonetheless.

The centerpiece of the memorial is a massive square canopy of dark gray metal with a diamond-shaped skylight in its center. Hanging from the canopy are 800 weathered steel columns. Each column represents a county (or, for areas in which lynchings were less common than in the Deep South, an entire state) and is engraved with the names and death dates of the victims who were lynched there. The columns vaguely resemble vertical coffins, and their rusted exteriors evoke different shades of scarred brown skin.

A walkway passes beneath the columns and follows the sharp turns of the canopy's lopsided square. My father and I walked slowly along the first side of the square, searching for Maryland's column. The columns are arranged alphabetically, first by state, then by county. The ones near the entrance rest on the ground, and the names inscribed on them are easy to read. As we rounded the first turn, the floor sloped downward, and the columns appeared to gradually rise. When we reached the second turn, they towered above our heads, and the names of the victims could hardly be made out under the shadow of the canopy. When we reached the end of the walkway, which loops back to where it begins but ends several feet lower, we stepped out from beneath the canopy and into the bright middle, where a short stone path leads to the peak of a central grassy hill. Only from that vantage point could we spy our home state's column hanging along the structure's inner edge.

It was hard to discern the twenty-nine names and dates engraved on Maryland's column from this distance. A memorial aide led us to a patch of earth on the south-facing side of the property. There, lying prostrate in six orderly rows, were exact replicas of the columns hanging in the memorial's canopy. We found Maryland's replica

column quickly. Instead of engraving Hance's full name, the EJI opted to use his nickname, "Ben."

These replicas are meant to be claimed by their respective counties and states and installed as local monuments. The EJI will begin the process of vetting and fulfilling requests in 2019, and as the columns begin to be claimed, it will be easy to tell which localities have reckoned with their histories of racial violence. The columns of those communities that have not will be trapped in limbo, exposed both to the elements and the public's gaze, until they are claimed.

The grounds were quiet, not in the abandoned way that downtown was, but respectfully quiet, cathedral quiet. The reflections of the visitors were interrupted only by the fathers in family reunion T-shirts calling after their children, and by the occasional plane passing overhead on its way to Montgomery Regional. My father was regarding a sculpture of ten or so people whose torsos and legs were encased in a stone block but whose arms were raised above their heads. They looked as if they were drowning, or as if they were presenting their empty hands to the viewer to prove they were unarmed. It was difficult to gauge the mood of my father, a stony man by nature. He met the figures' level gazes and seemed to be deep in thought about a type of history that neither he, nor I, had ever been taught in school.

After visiting the memorial, my father and I ordered an Uber to the corner of Washington Avenue and Union Street. Tourist sites aren't open late on weekends in Montgomery, and we arrived at the First White House of the Confederacy just an hour before it closed. The docent, a tall white man wearing a pastel polo shirt and pleated pants, spoke with the upbeat tone of a First Lady giving a tour of the West Wing. *Here we have the Davis family Bible. And here we've hung up Mr. and Mrs. Davis' portraits. And here we can all see Mrs. Davis' china (very fragile!).*

The house is small and rather unmemorable for a presidential mansion, save an upstairs room lined with a dozen or so glass display cases. These cases house war memos, cockades, .58 caliber "Minie-ball" bullets, multiple Southern Crosses of Honor, Jefferson Davis' old tobacco pipe, transcripts of letters between Davis and other Confederate leaders, a set of Turkish coffee cups, a golden pen, Mrs. Davis' cherished gray-and-white cameo necklace, and a portion of the Confederate bunting that lay over Davis' casket while his body was lying in state. The bunting was wrinkled and tattered and fraying at every seam, and over the past one hundred and thirty years, the red and blue dyes of the fabric had muted into nearly the same shade of gray. My father and I had been examining the memorabilia for just a few minutes when he unexpectedly left the room, as if to say: *There is not much I need to see here.*

Early the next morning we checked out of our hotel, loaded up the Impala, and hit the road home. We took I-85 north out of Montgomery and toward Atlanta, where we merged onto I-20. As my father drove, I thought of the thread-bare bunting on display in the Davis family's former home. I took comfort in the fact that certain memories and allegiances will always fade. I noticed on the return trip that nearly every county we drove through had a column waiting for it in Montgomery, and I wondered nervously how many would be claimed next year.

About four hours later, we approached the exit for I-95. We passed a sign telling us that Florence County, South Carolina, was just eight miles away. "Sounds familiar," I said. I remembered seeing Florence's column, along with the other 34 belonging to South Carolina, at the memorial. My father, characteristically silent, just nodded. He remembered it, too.

PHOTO BY **T.C. MARTIN**

EDUCATED WHILE INCARCERATED

A NEW INITIATIVE BRINGS YALE TO A CONNECTICUT PRISON

BY **ANASTASIA HUFHAM**

THERE IS A LARGE, BRICK BUILDING in Cheshire, Connecticut with imposing rust-brown columns out front. Inside, male students ranging from 16 to 24 years old study for exams and chat with professors. It looks a bit like an avant-garde high school, but the facility is actually home to Cheshire Correctional Institution, where student-inmates take some of the same courses as Yale students, 18 miles away.

James Jeter served 20 years in Cheshire, where he took 22 courses and worked towards an undergraduate degree, resulting in his current enrollment as an undergraduate student at Trinity College. During his sentence, Jeter also manufactured plastic bags, worked as a janitor, and tutored inmates for their GEDs.

But many of his jobs, Jeter said in an interview with *The Politic*, felt like "slave labor."

"It's not necessarily hard work," he said. "But the relationship between you and your employer is really demeaning."

JETER IS NOT ALONE in recognizing the dire working conditions in penal institutions. From August 21 to September 9, incarcerated individuals across the U.S. went on strike to protest inhumane labor and living conditions.

About 2.3 million men and women are incarcerated in the U.S. today, and thousands of them have jobs, working in kitchens, cleaning bathrooms, and performing strenuous labor to ensure that prisons run effectively. According to the Marshall Project, state and federal prisoners are paid, on average, 20 and 31 cents per hour, respectively, for their work, and many of them work between eight and ten hours per day. This fall, protestors participated in work strikes, hunger strikes, and boycotts, meaning that inmates stopped spending money in commissary. Organizers issued ten national demands, two of which called for expanded and improved educational opportunities for inmates.

Jeter, like the strikers, sees education as a meaningful alternative to menial labor and hopes that other incarcerated individuals can reap the benefits of higher education as he did. His conviction in the importance of empowering inmates through education brought him to the Yale Prison Education Initiative (YPEI), which makes Yale courses accessible to incarcerated students in Connecticut.

During the summer of 2018, YPEI piloted a college education program that allowed incarcerated individuals to obtain academic credit for Yale courses taught by Yale professors and graduate students.

Zelda Roland '08 GRD '16, the founding director of YPEI, believes the initiative's mission is inseparable from Yale's: like Yale, YPEI seeks exceptional students who are eager to learn and offers them a liberal arts education.

"The same benefits that you would argue a liberal arts education has for anyone from all over the world—that's what we're offering to people who happen to be incarcerated," Roland said.

During the summer of 2018, YPEI began offering Yale classes to a group of students in the Connecticut prison system who had been selected through a competitive admissions process. Their classes are identical to those offered on Yale's campus during the academic year, down to the syllabi. A Yale pennant hangs in every prison classroom.

ROLAND MET JETER when she was working as a volunteer in the Wesleyan Center for Prison Education at Cheshire Correctional Institution, where he was serving time for the 1997 murder of 19-year-old Walter Jaynes.

Born and raised in New Haven, Jeter remembers dedicating himself to school and family when he was young. But when he was nine years old, his father passed away, following a long struggle with drug addiction. At age 17, Jeter, who had started dealing drugs, was robbed; lat-

er, in an attempt to retaliate, Jeter shot the person he thought was the robber. He later learned that the man he killed had nothing to do with the robbery. In 2000, Jeter was sentenced to 30 years in prison, but he received parole in 2017.

Today, Roland and Jeter work at neighboring desks in their second-floor Dwight Hall office on Yale's Old Campus. They are united by their mission: to bring educational programs to incarcerated individuals.

While in prison, Jeter took Wesleyan courses through the Wesleyan Center for Prison Education. Many of them were writing-intensive, and he had to compose analytical essays. "I learned how to research, how to organize my thought processes," he said. Now, he added, "I can stand on my own thoughts."

Cheryl Greenberg, a Trinity College professor who taught Jeter in Cheshire Correctional Institution, said that he was an active and interesting participant in discussions who immediately stood out in the classroom. With each session, Jeter continued to impress her, often staying after class to ask her about the material and upcoming assignments. "His papers started out somewhere in the B-range, and then went up to the A-minus-range," Greenberg said. "And then he was getting solid A's."

Greenberg's standards for Jeter were no different than her standards for students at Trinity, she said. Inevitably, though, the constraints of prison life make learning profoundly different. Greenberg's students have almost no control over their daily schedules. Lacking access to internet, audio, and visual resources, they could not conduct their own outside research, so Greenberg compiled paper sources for them before class. And many of her Cheshire students entered the classroom with less experience in writing than her students at Trinity.

Some readings Greenberg would have liked to assign were not allowed. Though she usually concludes her Trinity course with *The New Jim Crow* by Michelle Alexander, an exposé on the U.S. prison system, she had to adjust her curriculum because the correctional facility did not approve it.

The coursework resonated with her incarcerated students in ways that sometimes surprised Greenberg. She remembers asking a class for opinions on a runaway slave narrative, expecting obvious answers about the horrors of slavery. One student raised his hand and connected the book to his own experience in what was, to him, another kind of slavery: prison.

Greenberg remembers him saying, "When I got here, I took one look at the walls and one look at the barbed wire, and thought, 'I can't stay here. I've gotta get out of here. And then I thought, if I escape—if I run away—I will never be truly free. I will always have to be hiding. And so I decided to stay."

Greenberg was stunned. "I thought, Oh my God, in my 30 years of teaching this book, I have never thought of it in quite that way," she said.

Jeter's academic experience was similarly illuminating. "Prison is a place where you don't really get to be vulnerable, so education in prison creates vulnerability," he said.

"Prison is a place where you are held accountable for one act, or several acts, but you are always held accountable for them in your daily interactions with the authorities, at all times. There is no redeeming," Jeter explained.

For him, education made room for mistakes and personal growth. Learning felt humanizing—unlike making bags or mopping floors.

The dehumanizing effects of labor have played a key role in driving prison strikes, past and present. Greenberg was teaching about Attica, an uprising in a New York prison in the 1960s, during this year's prison strike.

"I was really struck by how the things that they were protesting then are the same things that they are protesting now," she said. "I think that this strike is so powerful in bringing the attention to where it needs to be, and now, I just hope people are willing to listen."

To Jeter, the power of education is at the heart of rehabilitation.

"Education allows a lot of men to see that they don't need redemption, that they were never undeemed," he theorized. It builds confidence, too.

"I can just stand on some merit of my own and grow," he said.

"IT'S NOT NECESSARILY HARD WORK, BUT THE RELATIONSHIP BETWEEN YOU AND YOUR EMPLOYER IS REALLY DEMEANING."

BUDGET PROBLEMS IN BRIDGEPORT

IN CONNECTICUT'S LARGEST CITY, THE MONEY HAS DRIED UP

By **Alan May**

WRITING BRIDGEPORT'S BUDGET was never going to be easy. According to census data, the city has a median household income of about 43,000 dollars (compared to 72,000 dollars statewide); 18 percent of its 147,000 residents have a four-year college degree (against 38 percent statewide); and the median owner-occupied home value is 168,000 dollars (compared to 269,000 dollars statewide). Twenty-two percent of residents live in poverty, as compared to ten percent statewide, and Bridgeport has long been stereotyped as corrupt and dilapidated. Connecticut Public Radio journalist Colin McEnroe '76 told salon.com, "No outsider, including me, really understands it."

1. BEFORE THE REVALUATION

For most of the 2000s and part of the 2010s, Bridgeport seemed to be defying its odds. In March 2003, longtime Mayor Joseph Ganim was convicted of taking bribes; he resigned the next month and was packed off to a federal prison in Fort Dix, New Jersey. (He had been elected in 1991, in part on a pledge to fix the city's finances after his predecessor Mary Moran unsuccessfully tried to declare municipal bankruptcy.)

Ganim's successor, John Fabrizi, a former president of the City Council, also found his administration engulfed in scandal when he admitted to abusing cocaine in 2006, but the city's financial picture was unquestionably improving. Each year, Connecticut municipalities compile a "Grand List" of taxable real and personal property; between fiscal years 2008 and 2015, Bridgeport's Grand List grew from 5.6 billion dollars to 7.2 billion dollars, giving the city some much-needed flexibility in the form of higher tax revenue.

In an interview with *The Politic*, Bill Finch, Bridgeport mayor from 2007 to 2015, described his time in office as relatively calm for the city's budget. The city was often "a couple million dollars in the hole at the end of the year," he noted, but the problems could be resolved each year, and the budget gaps never grew out of hand.

"It was kind of a miracle that we didn't have to cut services," he said, pointing to concessions from city employees as a useful cost-cutting measure and emphasizing that he tried to reduce city expenses and spur economic development with a focus on environmental sustainability. With the exception of the city's long-term obligations such as pension plans—there was "not enough *there* there" to fund them fully, Finch says—things seemed to be going well.

By 2014, though, storm clouds were visible. State law requires municipalities to reassess their property values—essentially, to rewrite their Grand Lists—every five years. Bridgeport hadn't done it since 2008, and it was painfully obvious that property values had dropped since then because of the financial crisis.

On February 24, 2014, City Councilman Richard Paoletto and Finance Director Anne Kelly-Lenz appeared before the Planning and Development Committee of the Connecticut General Assembly and asked them to waive state law and delay the revaluation for two years. The Grand List was on the hook, and Kelly-Lenz explained that it was almost certain to shrink substantially if the city had to revalue now, with adverse consequences for Bridgeport residents.

"This request is based on an historic economic recession which has had such an effect on the entire United States economy resulting in corresponding record high levels of subprime lending defaults and foreclosures that impacted Connecticut cities, particularly Bridgeport," she told the committee.

Despite some concerns from legislators ("[Why] will the problem go away two years from now?" asked then-State Representative Bill Aman, R-South Windsor), the General Assembly bought Kelly-Lenz's argument that prosperity was just around the corner for Bridgeport, and the revaluation was delayed, as the city had requested. Between fiscal 2011 and fiscal 2015, the Grand List grew by a little more than 140 million dollars.

2. GANIM, REVALUATION, AND THE FALLOUT

Meanwhile, Ganim, who had been released from prison in 2010, was planning his comeback. Although he was unable to regain his law license, he and his brother started a consulting firm (Federal Prison Consultant LLC) to advise white-collar criminals, and he regained some credibility with a public apology at Bridgeport's East End Baptist Church on New Year's Day 2015. (He allowed that he had "made some errors in judgment" and said he was "truly sorry.") In May, he was officially a candidate for his old job, and by December he was back in the mayor's office after dispatching seven opponents, including Finch, the incumbent mayor.

When Ganim reentered office, he was in the hot seat for the budget disaster that everyone knew was coming. It is hard to say whether deferring the revaluation averted an even worse outcome, but Bridgeport's finances were now on shaky footing. The value of the Grand List, according to the city itself, fell by

more than one billion dollars, or around 15 percent, between fiscal years 2015 and 2016.

Like many municipalities, Bridgeport depends in large part on property tax revenue, which in 2017 made up more than half of its roughly 550 million dollar annual budget. If the value of the Grand List had fallen by 15 percent, there was an easy way to continue collecting the roughly 300 million dollars in taxes the city would need: raise the mill rate.

There were only two obstacles.

First, Bridgeport's taxes were already high. At 42.198 mills (4.2198 percent) for fiscal 2016, they were above those of neighboring towns, and, in fact, above those of most other municipalities in Connecticut (Hartford at 74.29 mills and Waterbury at 58.22 being two of the notable exceptions). This is fairly normal. Large cities with lower property values than the surrounding suburbs often have to charge higher property tax rates just to try to keep up with the level of services that competing municipalities can provide. But because increasing the mill rate can scare off investment, it's not at the top of anyone's wish list.

The second obstacle was more of a problem: Ganim had campaigned on a promise not to raise taxes. Now he was looking at revenues that were 20 million dollars short of what he wanted. He raised the mill rate anyway, with the City Council's approval, and for fiscal 2017 it jumped more than 25 percent, to 54.37.

Many homeowners were furious. In Black Rock, a prosperous neighborhood overlooking Long Island Sound, property values hadn't fallen very much if at all, and many residents found that their tax bills had jumped impressively. Black Rock residents who criticized the city included David Walker, the former comptroller general of the United States, and the controversy even made its way into *The New York Times*, which profiled one man, Peter Spain, who applied for a Guinness World Record for the "highest one-year increase in property tax rate in the world." (Guinness declined to bite, although Spain was eventually elected to the City Council.)

Two years later, the dust has settled somewhat. But whether the tax increase was a good idea or not, it's hard to say that Bridgeport is on the right footing financially. In October 2017, Moody's cut the credit rating for a number of the city's general obligation bonds—an indicator of the municipality's fiscal health—from A2 to Baa1, placing them in the "moderate credit risk" category.

Even though the downgrade was connected to the State of Connecticut's bleak financial picture, which endangers the revenue municipalities can expect to receive from the state government (and even though Fitch and Standard & Poor's rated many of the same bonds higher), low ratings tend to increase Bridgeport's borrowing costs, and the city has to borrow money to meet its cash-flow needs, which does not inspire investor confidence.

Meanwhile controversy erupted this spring over Ganim and the City Council's decision to nearly flat-fund Bridgeport schools, and on top of all this residents like John Marshall Lee '64, a longtime budget-watcher, insurance agent, and chairperson of the Press and Publicity Committee of the Greater Bridgeport chapter of the NAACP, remain concerned that the taxes could deter economic development.

"Why would anybody come to Bridgeport with a high tax rate?" Lee asked, in an interview with *The Politic*.

The picture isn't totally bleak, according to people who are responsible for the city's finances. "I'm actually somewhat optimistic" about getting back to a higher bond rating with Moody's, Kenneth Flatto, Bridgeport's current finance director, told *The Politic*; the rating agency has revised its outlook from "negative" to "stable."

Flatto also points out that the economic development prospects might not be as bad as Lee says, rattling off a list of real estate projects downtown and projecting that a new gas-fired electric plant, due to start operating in 2019, will add substantially to annual property tax revenue once it's complete.

Denese Taylor-Moye, a co-chair of the Budget and Appropriations Committee on the City Council, agrees that economic development is "picking up, looking good" and, like Flatto, says she anticipates that investments in the city (the Steel Point development on the waterfront, for example) will pay dividends in the coming years.

"This is the time for a better Bridgeport," she said in an interview with *The Politic*. Economic development may even arrive in the form of a highly anticipated MGM casino.

3. THE PATH FORWARD

A lot of this optimism seems to be subject to Flatto's caveat that development will be forthcoming "if the economy stays reasonable." That may well work out, especially since millennials seem to like living in large cities, and Bridgeport has a number of advantages: a reasonable cost of living, the University of Bridgeport, a large waterfront park and beach, and a revitalizing downtown area, to name a few. But

what can the city do in the meantime to avoid future tax increases or service cuts that could harm its residents? It's up for debate.

One way to address the problem is to rein in employment costs. Like a number of government employers, Bridgeport offers its employees defined benefit pension plans. In contrast with defined contribution plans, defined benefit pensions guarantee employees a certain dollar amount of income in retirement; in Bridgeport's case, that figure is determined by a formula based on the employees' salaries during their time with the city. Defined benefit pensions are often expensive, and they place a large amount of risk with taxpayers. Even if the assets used to fund the pensions don't earn as much interest as expected or more beneficiaries than anticipated claim benefits, the city has to come up with enough money to pay out, which can strain its overall finances.

Some observers—Lee among them—say the city should consider a defined contribution pension plan so that employees accept some risk that their benefits will be smaller if adverse events occur. (Lee also suggests that the city could save by cutting expenditures like medical care for retirees that fall under "other post-employment benefits": "This is absurd, the way it has grown," he said of OPEB.) But it is hard to imagine that Bridgeport employees would be enthusiastic about receiving less generous benefits or that the unions that represent them would be eager to acquiesce.

Another option is just to cut city services, but that, too, is a risky tactic. In a city with low educational attainment, is it a good idea to reduce funding for the schools? In fiscal 2017, the State of Connecticut paid Bridgeport 164 million dollars (over 25 percent of the total city budget) through Education Cost Sharing (ECS), a program that is intended to relieve the burden on poorer school districts. But according to the state Department of Education, Bridgeport high schools posted a graduation rate of only 75 percent last year, compared to 88 percent statewide.

If Seaside Park is one of the city's selling points, is it reasonable to cut funding for parks and recreation? And while it might be possible to save on the Police Department, which cost more than 100 million dollars last year, that seems likely to leave residents less safe.

For many expenditures, cuts would lead to a "programmatic impact" that hurts citizens, Flatto explained. How far do you go with the cuts?

Bridgeport also has the option of petitioning

FOR MANY EXPENDITURES, CUTS WOULD LEAD TO A "PROGRAMMATIC IMPACT" THAT HURTS CITIZENS, FLATTO EXPLAINED. HOW FAR DO YOU GO WITH THE CUTS?

the State of Connecticut to designate it as a Tier III distressed municipality, a legal classification that would make it eligible to receive aid and supervision from the state Municipal Accountability Review Board. The MARB is supposed to put struggling governments on a sounder fiscal footing, but it involves substantial red tape and requires participating towns to give up their authority to make assumptions about property tax or state aid revenue. ("There's a lot of drawbacks," Secretary of the Office of Policy and Management Ben Barnes has previously pointed out.)

Only one municipality, Hartford, has asked for Tier III designation; another, West Haven, was placed into Tier III because it issued debt to finance a deficit, triggering automatic state oversight. And the funds that the MARB offers may not be enough to persuade Bridgeport to give up any authority unless its fiscal distress becomes much more serious.

More than any other institution, the Bridgeport Public Schools seem to be at the center of the problem. They are very expensive (at nearly 260 million dollars in fiscal 2017, education accounted for more than 45 percent of the city's expenditures) and they continue to underperform relative to other districts in Connecticut. The Board of Education and the city government have had a strained relationship in recent years. The tension is exacerbated by the fact that each body has little control over the other's appropriations process—Board of Education member Hernan Illingworth, for instance, suggested to *The Politic* that "the city should do more" to control costs.

And yet it's hard to see even an aggressive cost-cutting initiative in the public schools as a practical solution. Asked whether school funding was sufficient, Board of Education member Maria Pereira told *The Politic* that "it hasn't been adequate in Bridgeport for three decades." Illingworth, in response to the same question, flatly answered, "definitely not."

Even Chris Taylor, a Republican board member who told *The Politic* he believes "the funding is adequate," noted that he was concerned the school dis-

BRIDGEPORT HAS TO PICK THE BEST FROM A SET OF BAD CHOICES.

trict did not have enough paraprofessionals on staff and said he had encountered bad facilities as chair of the board's Facilities Committee. And both Pereira and Illingworth argued that the state's ECS program is not meeting Bridgeport's needs, saying respectively that the state can't be counted on to fully fund the formula—it's endangered by the state's budget crisis—and that the formula itself does not allocate enough to Bridgeport. Taylor also suggested that ECS funding had been mismanaged.

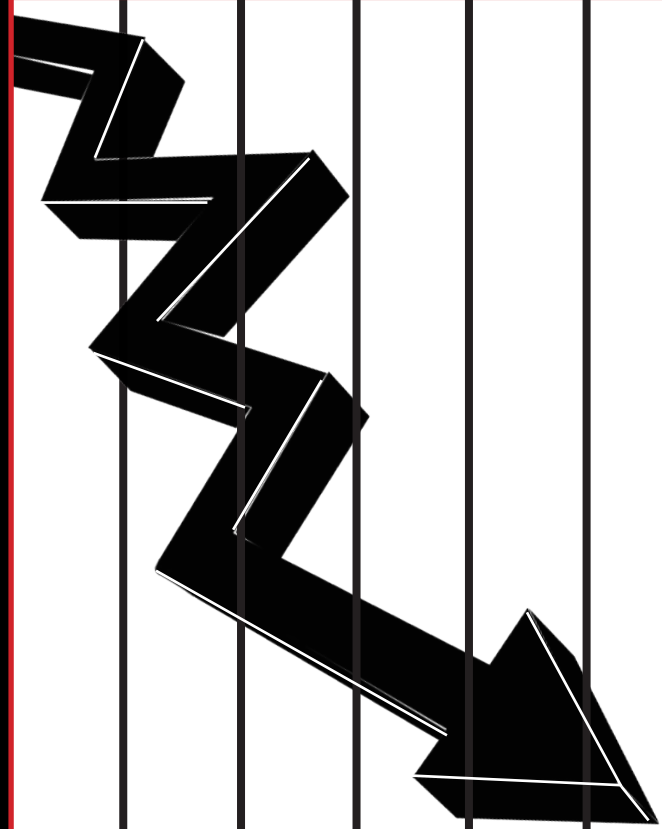
Some observers have also argued for more comprehensive reforms. Finch, describing Bridgeport's budget as a "difficult situation regardless of who the mayor is," pointed to the municipal organization of Connecticut as the source of the problem: there are simply "too many governments," he says, arguing that towns could reduce costs by collaborating or consolidating.

Proposals for regionalization face ideological and practical obstacles: Pereira, for instance, argues that local school boards are best positioned to supervise public education, and it seems unlikely that residents of more prosperous, whiter towns in Fairfield County would be eager to accept a merger with Bridgeport. But fewer, larger, municipalities might be able to address a number of the problems that are near-impossible to solve under the current system. (Connecticut has no county governments.)

Bridgeport has to pick the best from a set of bad choices. Because of Connecticut's ongoing fiscal crisis, municipalities are unlikely to receive much more state aid than they do now at any time in the foreseeable future. That leaves the city dependent on revenue sources within the city limits, and any tax rate is almost certain to be either too low to meet the city's obligations or too high for Bridgeport to foster the robust market in goods, services, and real estate that will sustain long-term economic growth. Many of the possible solutions—more taxation, spending cuts, state oversight, merging with other municipalities—come with obvious adverse consequences.

But there may be some light at the end of the tunnel. If Flatto and Taylor-Moye are right about the new power plant, the Steel Point development, and downtown revitalization—and, in particular, if MGM is able to put a casino in Bridgeport—it's possible that the city could grow its way out of this conundrum.

That would be a boon to the many Bridgeport families who don't get the same shot at success as their neighbors in more prosperous towns throughout Fairfield County. Residents of Bridgeport, who are disproportionately poor and disproportionately people of color, have been dealt a worse hand than their neighbors. But with luck, the city's problems may not prove to be permanent.



BlacKkKlansman is the story of a bond between two men, each on the periphery of whiteness, defining their identities in the face of hatred.

BY **SHANNON SOMMERS**

Skin in the Game

Spike Lee's *BlacKkKlansman* Shows the Darkness and Durability of American Racism

A SINGLE LIGHT glares so strongly upon the nameless white race theorist that he nearly blends into the backdrop, a screen playing the racist 1915 Civil War epic, *The Birth of a Nation*. He asserts that the 1970s were "marked by the spread of integration and miscegenation," hellbent on destroying "true, white Americans."

As he trips over his own words, the speech's fumbled delivery undercuts its heinous intent. The speaker's venomous ranting about black "radicals" and "blood-sucking" Jews highlights the horrors of our national past, but the uneasy familiarity of the language also creates a sense of timelessness, a present urgency, because we have heard this rhetoric before.

Spike Lee's *BlacKkKlansman*, a period satire released this August, tells the story of Ron Stallworth, the first black cop in the Colorado Springs police force, and his undercover mission to expose the local Ku Klux Klan (KKK) through remote contact. Unable to attend meetings, Ron enlists Flip, a white Jewish cop in his precinct, to join the KKK and infiltrate the organization.

Spike Lee has said that *BlacKkKlansman* cannot and should not be viewed as a comedy. Many scenes at the exposition seem ridiculous, products of the movie's ironies and contradictions, yet they hint at grave consequences. Ron's mission itself—his attempt to use remote contact to circumvent the consequences of race—is at once idealistic and insane. In the trailer, mere seconds after Stallworth lightheartedly grooms his afro, he tells a KKK leader over the phone, "I hate blacks. I hate Jews, Mexicans, and Irish, Italians and Chinese. But, my mouth to God's ears, I really hate those black rats, and anyone else really who doesn't have pure white Aryan blood running through their veins."

Yet, unlike Ron's portrayal of how bigotry manifests, the film shows the real KKK as people tethered to normalcy—people with homes and wives; people who refuse to say their organization's full name out loud, let alone muse about "pure white Aryan blood," but who still spend meetings planning to murder young black activists. Ron's work initially fails to materialize only because his blackness is inescapable: His first attempt to dismantle the KKK is limited to verbal charades and the code-switching language of phone calls.

Caleb Gayle writes in *The Guardian*, "[America's] neutered view of race, informed by bad recollections of history, forced Ron and continues to force many people of color to fit into boxes of docile activism." Ron's skin is a constant source of vulnerability. He cannot navigate public space without being reminded that, given the social and racial forces at play, merely existing is a political act. And because Ron is limited to his designated box, he cannot convincingly pretend to embody white supremacy. Ron is frustrated not merely because the KKK exists, but because he is incapable of penetrating it.

Ron recognizes this when he asks Flip for help. While the KKK viewed both black and Jewish people as enemies to whiteness, Flip's ability to pass as white is what allows him access to the Klan. There is no way to identify Jewishness from his language. Some of his facial features raise questions, but offer no definitive answer. When asked if he is Jewish, Flip replies, "I dunno, am I?"

Although Ron's commitment to his mission does not falter throughout the film, the audience watches as Flip becomes increasingly comfortable with the KKK members and adept at mimicking intolerance. He learns to mask knee-jerk repulsion with greater bigotry, including when he counters Holocaust denial by asserting, "The Holocaust was beautiful." For him and for the audience, it becomes increasingly difficult to distinguish between performance and reality.

While Ron can never disown his blackness, Flip, in a rare moment of vulnerability, reveals, "I'm Jewish, yes, but I wasn't raised to be. I was just another white kid." He later continues, "I never thought much about it. Now I think about it all the time." Flip's ability to come across as non-Jewish also allows him to disavow a marginalized part of his identity and persuade himself that white supremacy is not intimately personal. Flip confronts Ron: "For you it's a crusade. For me it's a job." Ron responds, "You're Jewish. They hate you. Doesn't that piss you off? Why are you acting like you don't got skin in the game?"

BlacKkKlansman is the story of a bond between two men, each on the periphery of whiteness, defining their identities in the face of hatred. Ron's position in white society is part of a larger conversation about what race means in America; there is no doubt that he knows the stake he has in dismantling the KKK. But as Flip becomes more absorbed in the vitriol of the KKK, he needs Ron to remind him how personal the threat of white supremacy remains, even when he can pretend to be a WASP (White Anglo-Saxon Protestant), even without any outward indications of his bloodline.

BlacKkKlansman's narrative ends with the distant glow of burning crosses under a dark Colorado sky. But the film is not over until it fades into video from the 2017 Unite the Right rally in Charlottesville. The movie's audience becomes one with the swarms of protesters, the high-pitched screams, the car that cuts across the screen and eventually kills Heather Heyer. The Charlottesville footage is grounded in its historical moment, but these images, like the clip at the movie's opening, also contain a certain element of atemporality. The smooth transition between film and newsreel images illustrates how little has changed, how deeply racial hatred is woven into America's national consciousness.

Faced with the immediacy of the Charlottesville footage, the audience, like Ron and Flip, is forced to consider how we see ourselves against the backdrop of white supremacy. As Ron cannot forget, and Flip comes to understand,

> we all have skin in the game.

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